Gluten-Free Tuna Mac •

A quick stovetop comfort dish that upgrades classic boxed mac and cheese into a savory weeknight supper. Warm herbs and a touch of acid cut through the rich, velvety cheese sauce so the pasta and tender flakes of tuna taste bright rather than heavy. Serves 3–4.

Ingredients

Whole milk . . . . . 2 cups
Dried onion flakes . . . . . 1 tsp.
Dried tarragon . . . . . 1/2 tsp.
Ground nutmeg . . . . . 1/8 tsp.
Salted butter, divided . . . . . 3 Tbsp.
White rice flour . . . . . 2 Tbsp.
Kosher salt, divided . . . . . 4 tsp.
White or black pepper . . . . . 1/2 tsp.
Ground mustard . . . . . 1/2 tsp.
Ground fennel . . . . . 1/8 tsp.
American cheese . . . . 1 slice (3/4 oz.)
Cheddar or Gruyère cheese . 4–6 oz.
Gluten-free elbow pasta . . . 6–8 oz.
Yellow mustard . . . . . 1 tsp.
White wine vinegar . . . . . 1 tsp.
Canned tuna . . . . . 1 can (6 oz.)
Dried parsley . . . . . 2 tsp.

Sauce

Bring a large pot of **water** to a boil — Shred **sharp cheddar** or **Gruyère cheese**

1. Warm 2 cups **whole milk**, 1 tsp. **dried onion flakes**, 1/2 tsp. **dried tarragon**, and 1/8 tsp. **ground nutmeg** in the microwave on *high* for *2–3 minutes* until steaming hot (*165°F*) and the **onion flakes** and **tarragon** soften.
2. Melt 2 Tbsp. **salted butter** in a medium saucepan over *medium heat* for *30–45 seconds* until foamy. Whisk in 2 Tbsp. **white rice flour** and cook for *1 minute* until smooth and bubbling.
3. Stir in 1 tsp. **kosher salt**, 1/2 tsp. **ground pepper**, 1/2 tsp. **ground mustard**, and 1/8 tsp. **ground fennel**. Cook, whisking, for *1 minute* until foamy, pale gold, and fragrant.

4. Whisk in the warm **milk** a splash at a time so the roux catches and stays smooth before adding more liquid.
5. Bring to a low simmer over *medium-low heat* and cook, whisking often, for *3–5 minutes* until smooth and thick enough to coat the back of a spoon (*185–195°F*). Continue simmering for *1–2 minutes* if any floury grit remains.
6. Reduce to *low heat*. Whisk in 1 slice **American cheese** until melted, about *30–60 seconds*. Add the shredded **cheddar** or **Gruyère cheese** a handful at a time, stirring until each handful melts smoothly before adding the next, about *2–3 minutes*.
7. Stir in the remaining 1 Tbsp. **salted butter** until melted. Taste and adjust **salt**. Keep on the *lowest heat* (below *180°F*) while the **pasta** cooks, stirring occasionally.

Finish

Drain **tuna**

1. Add 1 Tbsp. **kosher salt** and 6–8 oz. **gluten-free elbow pasta** to the boiling **water**. Boil over *medium-high heat* for *6–8 minutes*, stirring occasionally, until al dente (tender with a slight bite). Drain well and return the **elbow pasta** to the pot.
2. Remove the sauce from the heat and stir in 1 tsp. **yellow mustard** and 1 tsp. **white wine vinegar**.
3. Pour the cheese sauce over the **elbow pasta** in the pot, then add the drained **tuna** and 2 tsp. **dried parsley**. Fold gently for *1 minute* until coated and heated through. Taste for **salt** and serve hot.

Equipment Required

- Large pot (4–6 quart, for **pasta**)
- Medium saucepan (3-quart, for sauce)
- 4-cup microwave-safe measuring cup
- Box grater
- Colander and can opener
- Whisk and silicone spatula
- Measuring cups and spoons

Hints and Notes

Yield

- Serves 3–4 as a main dish

Mise en Place

- Start the **pasta water** heating first so it boils while the sauce simmers
- Shred **cheddar** or **Gruyère cheese** and drain **tuna** before starting the roux
- Warm the **whole milk**, **dried onion flakes**, **dried tarragon**, and **ground nutmeg** right before melting the **salted butter**

Ingredient Tips

- **White rice flour:** Use finely milled **white rice flour** so the sauce cooks up smooth
- **American cheese:** A single slice keeps the **cheddar** or **Gruyère** smooth and prevents the sauce from splitting
- **Cheddar** or **Gruyère:** Shred from a block (or blend both); pre-shredded **cheese** contains starches that make the sauce grainy
- **Gluten-free elbow pasta:** Corn-and-rice blends (such as Barilla or Jovial) hold their shape best. Use 6 oz. for a saucier dish or 8 oz. for a thicker coat
- **Canned tuna:** Drain well so excess **water** or **oil** does not thin the sauce

Preparation Tips

- Steeping the **dried onion flakes**, **dried tarragon**, and **ground nutmeg** in the warm **whole milk** softens the herbs and infuses the liquid without scorching
- Cooking the **roux spices** in the **salted butter** and **white rice flour** for *1 minute* brings out their aroma without burning
- Add the warm **milk** gradually at the start so the roux catches into a smooth paste before thinning
- **White rice flour** benefits from a gentle simmer (*185–195°F*) to lose its chalky texture and turn glossy
- Keep on *low heat* once the **cheese** is added; boiling above *190°F* can make the sauce grainy
- Stir in the **white wine vinegar** and **yellow mustard** right before combining with the **pasta** for a bright finish
- Fold the **tuna** gently at the end so the flakes stay intact

Make Ahead & Storage

- Best served right away while the sauce is hot and creamy
- Leftovers keep *3 days* refrigerated in an airtight container
- Reheat gently over *low heat* or in the microwave at *50% power* with a splash of **milk** to loosen the sauce
- Do not freeze; **gluten-free pasta** softens when thawed

Serving Suggestions

- Serve hot in bowls
- Top with crushed **potato chips** or toasted **gluten-free breadcrumbs** for crunch
- Pair with steamed **peas**, roasted **broccoli**, or a simple green salad
- Offer **hot sauce** or extra **black pepper** at the table